TWO

Contribution to the Transition

NELL · DAY 22,861 · SATURDAY 17 MAY 2025

THEY CALLED US in on a Saturday, which should have told me everything.

There were almond croissants on the boardroom table, fanned out on a white plate. Nobody touched them. Nine of us sat round the table in weekend clothes, and the croissants sat in the middle like a tenth person who'd come to the wrong meeting and was too polite to leave.

The man from head office had a lanyard and a clicker. He was younger than any of us and very kind, which was the worst part. He put a map of the country on the big screen, every Coyle's depot a small amber dot, and pressed the clicker, and the dots began to move.

"It's live," he said. "As of this morning."

I watched a lorry leave the northern depot and take a road I would never have chosen. Three minutes later the reason appeared: a closure on the motorway that none of us had heard about yet. It had seen the future, or near enough. It had seen it before I'd finished my coffee.

I remember thinking, with a professional admiration I've never quite forgiven myself for: *that's good.*

"Nobody's losing their job today," said the man from head office, and nine people heard the last word.

When it was over he wrapped the croissants in a paper napkin, all six, and took them with him. He saw me watching and smiled, a little embarrassed. "Shame to waste them," he said. He was right. That was the thing about him. He was right about everything.

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IT TOOK ELEVEN months. They were decent about it, which I'm told is rare. Nobody was walked out with a cardboard box. The team just got smaller, a month at a time, so gradually that you only noticed when you looked up and counted.

Priya went first, to a job up north she'd been sitting on for a year. Then the two lads on nights, whose shift simply stopped existing. Then Maureen from planning, sixty-one, who said she'd been meaning to retire anyway and cried in the car park where she thought nobody could see. Each of them got a card we all signed and a cake the system didn't eat.

By Christmas there were two of us and a contractor in a time zone I had to keep looking up. By February there was me.

I was kept on to *support the transition*. That meant sitting beside the routing system eight hours a day and telling it when it was wrong. It was hardly ever wrong, and when it was, it was wrong in ways I'd have been wrong too. It learned from me faster than I'd ever learned from anyone. I was training my replacement, and my replacement was a very good student.

It ran on something called Nimfold, which I'd seen on the news, through a cloud I'd also seen on the news. The contractor talked about both as if they were plumbing. *Nimfold's pushing an update tonight. The cloud's slow in the mornings.*

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WHEN I JOINED Coyle's I was twenty-six and knew nothing, and a man called Pete taught me everything.

Pete kept a green pen in his shirt pocket and corrected my spreadsheets with it in a small, upright hand. He never told me I was wrong. He'd circle a number, write *why?* in the margin, and go and make a cup of tea. Sometimes I sat with my circled number for a whole day before I understood it. That was how I learned the job: beside someone who already knew it, with a question in green ink and all the time in the world.

Pete retired in 2016 and died the year after Dad. At the funeral his daughter gave me a green pen from a box of them she'd found in his garage. It's in the drawer with the takeaway menus. I've never used it. I don't know what I'd circle.

The system doesn't circle anything. It doesn't ask *why?* I never once saw it wonder.

One Thursday in March it routed a refrigerated lorry from the container port through a town I knew was holding its market that morning. That wasn't in any data. You knew it because a driver had once been stuck behind a cheese stall for forty minutes and told you about it, in detail, twice. I watched the little amber dot head for the market, reached for the override, and stopped.

Why?

Not why the system had done it. Nobody had told it about the cheese stall, because the man who knew had taken early retirement and moved to Spain. I meant: why was I about to fix it? In three weeks nobody would be at this desk to know about markets. The lorry would go through the town anyway, somebody would wait forty minutes for their fish, and it would be nobody's fault, because there'd be nobody.

I fixed it. Old habits, Pete would have said. But I remember those four seconds. They were the first time in eleven months I'd seen the shape of the thing: not a machine taking my job, but a world quietly arranging itself so that no one would be left to notice what was lost.

The fish arrived on time.

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THE LETTER CAME in March, on Coyle's paper with the old lorry logo, signed by a director I'd met twice. It thanked me for my *contribution to the transition*.

I read it at the kitchen table with a cup of tea going cold. On the shelf opposite was my father's crossword dictionary, its spine broken in three places from forty years of opening at the same letters. Under the tea was my rent statement, doing duty as a coaster: some property services company, a logo like a bird, a payment reference as long as a sentence. I'd paid them for six years and couldn't have told you their name.

Contribution, as if I'd put money in a tin. *Transition*, as if I were a season, and it was simply time for me to turn.

There would be one last project before my notice ended. The company's archive was going digital, and "given your long familiarity with our records", would I oversee the review?

They wanted the person they were letting go to decide what to keep.

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APRIL 2026

THE ARCHIVE WAS a storage unit by the old rail yard, one of a row of identical units with roller doors and fluorescent strips that took a moment to make up their minds. You let yourself in with a keycard. It beeped going in and beeped coming out. I noticed that the first day and stopped noticing by the second. You stop hearing what a building says about you if it says it politely enough.

Inside was eighty years of paper in cardboard boxes gone soft at the corners: manifests, vehicle logs, bills of lading, a lifetime of things moved from one place to another and somebody writing it down.

People think archive work is boring, and they're right, but in the wrong way. After the first few hundred sheets your eyes stop reading and start *sorting*. Paper from the same year weighs the same in your hand. Same typeface, same tired clerk's initials in the corner. Your attention goes quiet, and all that's left is a low hum that only changes when something doesn't fit.

I worked like that for three weeks, eating lunch on an upturned crate and listening to trains I couldn't see. For the first time in a year I was good at something nobody could do better, because nobody else had been asked.

On Monday the twentieth of April, at about four in the afternoon, the hum changed.

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THE BOX SAID **1971 Q1 — MISC.** in marker faded to the colour of weak tea. It was under forty others.

It smelled of nothing, then of dust, then of something sweeter underneath, like a church.

Halfway down, a single manifest. Standard Coyle's form of the period. I'd handled a thousand that month.

My hands stopped before I knew why.

The weight. That was the first thing. Every Coyle's manifest has a weight, because weight is what we bill by, and this one had a neat pencil line through the box.

No charge. No rate. No invoice number. From a firm that has never moved a paperclip for free.

Where the date should have been, someone had written **D. 3062**. A docket number, I thought. I went and checked the dockets. It wasn't.

Collected from somewhere called **Harrowgate House**. Delivered to **The Ashby Trust**, care of a PO box. The cargo line had been typed on a machine whose *e* sat slightly high:

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OFFICE EQUIPMENT — TELETYPE APPARATUS, 1
UNIT. HANDLE AS INSTRUCTED.
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And across the bottom, in purple, from a rubber stamp, slightly crooked, as if pressed by someone who had done it many times and stopped looking:

FOR THE LONG WEATHER

No company name. No logo. Four words in the colour you'd choose for a wedding invitation.

I sat on my crate with the sheet in both hands. The strip light ticked. Beyond the yard a train went past and didn't stop.

I didn't feel afraid. I'd like to say I did; it would make me sound wiser. What I felt was *recognised*. For eleven months I'd been told, kindly, that the thing I was good at no longer mattered. And here was a piece of paper made, by someone careful, to look exactly like the thousand around it, and it had failed, and I was the only person alive who could have noticed.

I did what I'd have done with any discrepancy. I went through the rest of the box, then the two boxes either side of it, every sheet, fast, the way you check the other tyres after a puncture. Ordinary manifests. Weights, rates, initials. Not one more pencil line. Not one more stamp. Whoever had pressed it had done it many times, somewhere. Just not here.

I put it in a plastic sleeve and into my bag, which was almost certainly against company policy. At the door I swiped out. The keycard beeped.

Above the door, tucked into the corner where the roller housing met the wall, a small red light was on.

I'd walked under it twice a day for three weeks. I had never once seen it. I stood there with my bag against my hip and told myself it had always been on, and that it watched for burglars, and that burglars don't want paper.

Then I pulled the roller door down and went home.

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I COULDN'T SLEEP, so at eleven I rang Danny.

Danny Kessler was a union rep for twenty years, until there was no union left to represent, and now he delivers parcels for an app that rates him out of five. He answered on the second ring, just in from the van, still in his jacket. People who drive for apps don't sleep either. He was on 4.9, which he called the most stressful number of his life.

I read it to him twice.

"It's a tax dodge," he said.

"You haven't seen it."

"Don't need to. Rich people moving things off the books. I used to sit across the table from the men who signed them." The click of a kettle. "Why are you whispering?"

I hadn't known I was. I told him I'd send a photo. He said he'd look in the morning, and then he said what he always says at the end of a call, as if it were part of goodbye: "Don't let it get in your head, Nell."

It had been in my head since four o'clock.

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AT ONE IN the morning I opened my laptop at the kitchen table, opposite my father's dictionary and beside my rent-statement coaster, and started a blog.

I want to say I had a plan. What I had was a sheet of paper that didn't add up, a skill nobody wanted, and the feeling I'd had all my working life that if something isn't written down, it hasn't happened. The routing system could plan a route. It could not, as far as I knew, sit at a kitchen table at one in the morning and type *I know how this sounds.*

I needed a name that wasn't mine. My father used to call the hour after work, when he finally sat down with the crossword, his *vespers*: the evening prayer, though he hadn't been inside a church in thirty years. *Leave me to my vespers, Nellie.* So I was Vesper, because it was evening, and because I missed him.

I wrote for two hours. The croissants and the clicker. The box, the pencil line, the date that wasn't a date, the four words in purple. I wrote that I wasn't neutral, and that people should keep it in mind. I didn't write about the red light. I couldn't think how to make it sound like anything.

Twice I selected the whole thing to delete it. A woman who'd lost her job, finding herself in a box. I could hear exactly how it would read, because I'd have read it that way myself. Both times I put the cursor back at the end and wrote another line instead.

At ten past three I pressed *publish*.

Then I sat and looked at it: out in the dark, with nobody reading it, like a lantern in a field.